



Rising star: Quillan Salkild (L) shows his range. After a blistering debut, the Perth lightweight confirmed his substance with a composed, dominant decision over Yanal Ashmouze. GETTY IMAGES

FRESH BLOOD, REAL THREATS

The UFC spent much of 2025 celebrating its established stars, but beneath the spotlight, a **quieter shift** was underway.

Nigamanth P
nigamanth.p@thehindu.co.in

While the UFC's established legends continue to dominate headlines, 2025 offered clear evidence that the next generation of elite talent is already closing in. With a combined undefeated record over the last 12 months, these breakout newcomers shook up the rankings and staked their claim as the faces of the sport's future.

1. Quillan Salkild (Lightweight)
[W-10, L-1, D-0]

Perth's Quillan Salkild emerged as the standout debutant of the year. He ignited his UFC run at UFC 312 with a blistering 19-second knockout of India's

Anshul Jubli, before backing it up with a measured yet dominant unanimous decision over Yanal Ashmouze.

The defining moment of Salkild's campaign came in October. Accepting a short-notice bout against seasoned veteran Nasrat Haqparast in Abu Dhabi, the Luistro Combat Academy product silenced the Etihad Arena with a clinical first-round head-kick knockout. Finishing 2025 at 3-0 with two Performance of the Night bonuses, Salkild enters 2026 with the lightweight top 15 firmly within reach.

2. Ateba Gautier (Middleweight)
[9-1-0]

Cameroon's Ateba Gautier has rapidly established himself as one of the most intimidating young forces in the middleweight division.

Representing Manchester Top Team, the 23-year-old opened his UFC account with a decisive knockout victory over Jose Daniel Medina in Mexico City.

Gautier's momentum surged in the latter half of the year, as he secured back-to-back first-round stoppages against Robert Valentin and Tre'ston Vines. He is currently riding an eight-fight winning streak, with all eight victories coming by knockout.

Known for his explosive power and ferocious pace, Gautier boasts one of the highest ceilings in the division. Notably, despite his dominance, the young middleweight has remained vocal about the need for continued development, a grounded outlook that hints at longevity rather than a flash rise.

3. Kevin Vallejos (Featherweight)
[17-1-0]

Argentina's Kevin Vallejos rounded out the list with a Knockout of the Year contender in the final UFC event of 2025. Entering the season as a highly touted graduate of Dana White's Contender Series, Vallejos justified the hype by dispatching SeungWoo Choi before edging Danny Silva in a gritty, hard-fought sophomore outing.

Vallejos saved his most emphatic statement for veteran striker Giga Chikadze. In a stunning finish, the 24-year-old dropped Chikadze with a spinning backfist before unleashing a relentless follow-up barrage. Ending the year 3-0 and breaking into the featherweight rankings, Vallejos has transitioned from promising newcomer to legitimate contender.



DID YOU KNOW?

The record for the youngest fighter to win a UFC undisputed title belongs to Jon 'Bones' Jones. On March 19, 2011, Jones defeated Maurício 'Shogun' Rua at UFC 128 to claim the light heavyweight belt at just 23 years and 243 days old. In the women's divisions, the record is held by Rose Namajunas, who won the strawweight title by defeating Joanna Jedrzejczyk at UFC 217 at the age of 25 years and 128 days.